

Seawall height in South Palm Beach

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

SOUTH PALM BEACH • PALM BEACH COUNTY

No minimum set in local code

South Palm Beach sets no fixed seawall height. A new seawall or bulkhead cap must match the caps on neighboring properties as far as possible.

The detail

MINIMUM	None set
CAP ELEVATION	Shall conform to adjacent seawall/bulkhead caps insofar as possible - Sec. 26-835(d)
PERMIT	Engineer-sealed plans required - Sec. 26-835(c)
SEAWALL OR BULKHEAD	The code separates them by purpose: seawalls are massive structures resisting the full force of ocean waves, bulkheads retain fill against the local wave climate - Sec. 26-833
NO ANCHORS INTO BUILDINGS	No tieback system may be anchored to any building, and the engineer must certify the design meets Army Corps and state DEP requirements - Sec. 26-835(d)
INSPECTIONS	The building code administrator attends the first king pile or support sheet and inspects before backfilling anchors, any cast-in-place pour and the final cap pour; all materials must be certified by the manufacturer - Sec. 26-835(e)

Where this comes from: Town of South Palm Beach Code, Ch. 26 Art. IX Marine Structures, Div. 3 Bulkheads and Seawalls, Sec. 26-835; Secs. 26-833, 26-835(d)-(e)

Verified: 2026-10. Rules change — check the date above against today.

Before you call a contractor

1

Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

2**Get the existing elevation surveyed**

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

3**Ask what triggers the requirement**

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

4**Ask about building higher now**

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.